



Instructor Guide — Course 16, Lesson 3: Build Your Portfolio Website

Lesson Metadata

Field	Value
Course	16 — Build Your Professional Identity
Lesson	3 of 8 — Build Your Portfolio Website
Age	15–18
Duration	75–90 min
Difficulty	Beginner–Intermediate (basic HTML/CSS assumed from prior Lumexa courses)
Prerequisites	Lesson 2 (Strengths & Direction worksheet completed)
Tools	HTML, CSS, a code editor (VS Code recommended), the Portfolio_Website starter project
Objectives	Build a working, responsive multi-section portfolio site locally
Deliverables	A local, running portfolio site (not yet deployed — deployment is Lesson 7)
Skills developed	Semantic HTML structure, basic responsive CSS, information architecture for a personal site
Portfolio connection	This IS the portfolio website deliverable's skeleton — bio, brand, and case studies (L4–L6) get dropped into it

Lesson Overview

Students go from "I have a direction" to "I have a real, running website with my name on it." This lesson uses the provided [Portfolio_Website](#) starter project (in [Projects/Portfolio_Website/starter/](#)) so no student starts from a blank file — they customize a working structure rather than fighting boilerplate.

Instructor Prep

- Open [Projects/Portfolio_Website/completed/index.html](#) in a browser beforehand as the reference example to show.
- Have the [starter/](#) folder ready to distribute (zip, shared drive, or GitHub Classroom — instructor's choice).
- Confirm VS Code (or comparable editor) + Live Server extension (or `python3 -m http.server`) works on your teaching machine for a live-reload demo.

Required Files

- `Projects/Portfolio_Website/starter/` (given to students)
- `Projects/Portfolio_Website/completed/` (instructor reference only — do not distribute, since it spoils the exercise)

Teaching Sequence

Time	Activity
0–10 min	Show the completed reference site; walk through its 5 sections (Intro, About, Skills, Projects, Contact)
10–20 min	Distribute starter project; tour the file structure (<code>index.html</code> , <code>style.css</code> , <code>assets/</code>)
20–45 min	Guided coding: edit the Intro/Hero section together — name, tagline, direction from Lesson 2
45–65 min	Guided coding: About + Skills sections; introduce CSS Grid/Flexbox basics used in the starter
65–80 min	Independent work: students personalize colors/spacing (full branding comes in L5) and add placeholder project cards
80–90 min	Live-reload check on each student's site; wrap-up

Instructor Talking Points

- "A portfolio site is not a resume — it's a workspace where people can see and click through real things you built."
- "Five sections is enough: Intro, About, Skills, Projects, Contact. Don't over-build before you have content — content comes in Lessons 4–6."
- Explain semantic HTML briefly: `<header>` , `<main>` , `<section>` , `<footer>` vs. a page made entirely of `<div>` s, and why it matters (accessibility, SEO, maintainability).

Common Misconceptions

- "I need to build this from scratch to make it mine." → Customizing a solid structure is what real developers do; originality comes from content and design choices, not from avoiding starter code.
- "It has to look perfect today." → This is a working skeleton; brand polish happens in Lesson 5, real case studies in Lesson 4/6, and deployment in Lesson 7.

Likely Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

Issue	Fix
CSS changes not showing	Hard-refresh (Ctrl/Cmd+Shift+R); confirm the <code><link></code> tag path to <code>style.css</code> is correct

Issue	Fix
Layout breaks on resize	Check for a missing <code><meta name="viewport"></code> tag (already in starter — verify it wasn't deleted)
Local server won't start	Use VS Code Live Server extension as the simplest fallback; <code>python3 -m http.server 8000</code> as a backup
Nothing shows at all	Check the browser console (F12) for a typo'd tag or unclosed bracket

How to Review Student Work

Check: all 5 sections present, page doesn't visually break at 375px width (phone) and 1440px (laptop), no console errors, student's real name/direction (not the starter's placeholder text) is in place.

Lesson Close

Preview Lesson 4: "Next class we write your real bio and your first project case study — the words that go inside the structure you just built."